# THE RISE OF SAIL



**Warship fit for a king**
Henry VIII's trip to France in 1520 to meet with French King François I was a chance to show off the largest ship in his navy—possibly in all Europe—the *Henry Grace à Dieu*. Launched in 1514, the "Great Ship" was armed with 21 heavy bronze cannons and scores of smaller iron ones.

**THE EVOLUTION** of the three-masted sailing ship in the 15th century was a turning point in history. Armed with cannon, it was to give Europe global reach and maritime dominance. It also brought a fundamental change to naval warfare within Europe. Large sailing ships rendered maneuverable by a combination of square and lateen sails could outfight galleys, providing a superior platform for large numbers of cannon. These ocean-going ships began to shift the focus of European seapower from the Mediterranean to the Atlantic. Portugal showed the way in voyages down the African coast in the 15th century, but Spain was best placed to take the lead in ocean sailing because it was both a Mediterranean and an Atlantic power. Northern Europe had a long sailing tradition but its states rarely had the resources and political organization to maintain substantial fleets of warships until the 16th century.

## LONGSHIP RAIDERS

The first distinctive contribution of northern Europe to naval history was provided by the Viking warriors of Scandinavia from the 8th century. Their longships used sails and oars, like Mediterranean galleys, but were better able to function in heavier seas. Warriors doubled as oarsmen. Viking raiders devastated coastal settlements around the British Isles, besieged Paris, and even sailed into the Mediterranean and penetrated the Black Sea via the river systems of the Ukraine. Raiding parties grew into fleets as political consolidation created powerful Scandinavian kingdoms.

Viking ships were mostly employed in amphibious operations—the fighting took place on land—but crude sea battles occasionally took place with exchange of missiles and boarding with hand weapons. Although Anglo-Saxon England in particular tried to develop naval strength, there was little that any country—at least any as undeveloped as the states of northern Europe were at this time—could do to stop the Vikings landing forces or settlers whenever they wanted. England was invaded twice in 1066, by Scandinavians and their Frenchified descendants the Normans, without succeeding in mounting a response at sea.



**Sea battle at La Rochelle**
During the Hundred Years War sieges of ports often led to clashes at sea. In 1372 an English convoy taking supplies and reinforcements to their troops in La Rochelle lost all its ships to a Castilian squadron fighting for the French.

## ANGLO-FRENCH RIVALRY

The development of England and France as naval powers was slow. Medieval English fleets were improvised from a few king's ships, vessels provided by port towns and merchant cogs—round sailing ships—pressed into service for the purpose. Under French King Philip le Bel in the late 13th century the "clos des galées" for a while functioned as a kind of royal dockyard at Rouen, but there was nothing in northern waters that was remotely comparable with the size and sophistication of the great arsenals at Venice and Genoa. Henry VII finally established a permanent dock for the English king's ships at Portsmouth at the end of the 15th century.

Nevertheless, Anglo-French rivalry ensured that the English Channel became a focal point of naval operations from the 13th century onward. Large numbers of ships were sent in both directions to land troops, horses, and supplies, and for coastal raids, as when Southampton was sacked by French galleys in 1338. During the Hundred Years War, English military operations in northern France and Aquitaine would have been impossible without maritime support. Sea battles as such, however, were infrequent, and when they did take place, consisted mostly of fights between knights, men-at-arms, and archers on board ships.



**Catching the wind**
Many later Viking longships were equipped with a bronze weather vane that was attached to the tip of the prow. These were often decorated with grotesque animals.